

WARRIORS IN THEIR ELEMENT Soldiers of Indian Army's Gorkha Rifles perform a khukri dance

AFP

first put a halt to recruitment, it was the announcement of the new Agnipath scheme of recruitment into the Indian armed forces of personnel below the rank of officers in June 2022 that struck the real blow. Under the scheme, youths between the ages of 17.5 and 21 years would be inducted for a four-year tenure, at the end of which only 25 per cent would be inducted into regular service. Soon after, in August 2022, the Nepal government blocked the recruitment of their nationals when it was clear that the Agnipath scheme would equally apply to them. The ostensible reason is that it violates the tripartite agreement between India, Nepal and the United Kingdom signed in December 1947 that provided for the induction of Gorkhas in the Indian and British armies. The terms ensure equal pay, pension and other facilities on par with Indians. Though New Delhi has stated that none of that has changed, the Agnipath scheme has imposed a cold impasse on Nepali Gorkha recruitment that has yet to be resolved. It is understood that the expected socio-economic cost resulting from 75 per cent of Nepali Agniveers returning to their land has forced Nepal's hand.

Two years later, things have come to a head on two dimensions. Firstly, the retirement of around 14,000 Nepali Gorkha soldiers since 2021 has left a vaccum in the Indian army's ranks. Secondly, the whole issue has cast a pall over India-Nepal ties and can undermine India's strategic, soft-power reach—manifest in the retired and serving Gorkha soldiers in the Himalayan nation. Bilateral ties, too, have had